Add to these problems emotionally charged religious differences among the Arab people, as well as between Arabs and non-Arab Muslims in Iran and Afghanistan, who share with the Arabs only the commitment to destroy Israel.

In a schism reaching back centuries, based on differing interpretations of the prophet Muhammad's writings, the Muslim world split into two major factions, the Sunni and the Shia. Then these two groups split, with the Shia splintering into many rival groups, including several radical fundamentalist sects who demand the abolition of secular governments and their replacement by priestly theocracies; to achieve their goals, they have institutionalized murder and terrorism in the name of God, promising followers instant entry into Paradise if they die for their faith or kill an enemy who challenges it. Twice in recent years, America has lost loyal allies in the Middle East, the shah of Iran and Anwar Sadat, at the hands of these fanatics. I don't think you can overstate the importance that the rise of Islamic fundamentalism will have to the rest of the world in the century ahead—especially if, as seems possible, its most fanatical elements get their hands on nuclear and chemical weapons and the means to deliver them against their enemies.

In addition to the conflicts between Arab and Jew and between Muslim and Muslim, there are equally vicious rifts going back centuries between Christian sects, and between Christian sects and Muslim sects, especially in Lebanon. In 1943, the people of this former French colony reached an uneasy accord to share power, with the Christians given the upper hand based on a 1932 census that indicated they were in the majority: The president, who was to appoint the cabinet and prime minister, was to be a Maronite Christian; the prime minister was to be a Sunni Muslim, and the president of the Chamber of Deputies a Shiite Muslim. This agreement, however, did not anticipate a rapid growth after